

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-15
COVERAGE PERIOD	14–20 JUNE 2026
PUBLICATION DATE	2026-06-21
DOMINANT JUDGMENT	PRE-POSITIONING IS THE NEW BASELINE

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: The decisive shift this week is not a new attack — it is confirmation, from the UK’s national cyber authority, that state actors are deliberately pre-positioning inside the systems underpinning critical infrastructure so that access can be activated during a crisis. That warning landed the same week the U.S.–Iran ceasefire began to fracture, Ukrainian strikes took roughly a third of Russian refining capacity offline, and U.S. Coast Guard cyber teams documented remote-access and data-wipe tooling aboard sanctioned tankers. For Texas energy, finance, healthcare, defense-industrial, and AI/cloud operators, the question is no longer whether adversaries can get in. It is whether leadership controls the access pathways a geopolitical trigger would convert into leverage.

Board Implications This Week — Ask

Who has the authority and the means to sever a compromised vendor, remote-access pathway, or telecom/cloud dependency in the first hour of a crisis? If the answer lives only inside IT, that is the gap.

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Run a 72-hour dependency drill this week. Identify the top five external dependencies that would stop operations if degraded, and confirm in writing who can isolate each one.

Board Implications This Week — Document

Revalidate remote hires and contractors onboarded in the past six months — identity, laptop custody, location consistency, repository and cloud permissions. This is a governance record, not just an HR file.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Pre-approve emergency isolation authority and public-disclosure thresholds now, before a Hormuz or refinery-strike escalation forces the decision under pressure.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

Liberty CTI assesses with **high confidence** that state-linked access to critical infrastructure has shifted from opportunistic intrusion to deliberate pre-positioning for crisis leverage — and that the activation risk for Texas operators is now driven by geopolitical triggers, not by new intrusions.

This is a confirmed fact, not an inference: the head of the UK NCSC reported on 17 June that the agency managed more than 200 cyber incidents against critical national infrastructure and its supporting ecosystem in the year to May 2026, with roughly 75% linked to state actors — explicitly Russia, China, and Iran — and warned that adversaries are establishing footholds today to enable rapid, mass-disruption exploitation in a future conflict. The same target logic maps directly onto Texas, where energy, ports, hospitals, data centers, and defense suppliers depend on the same supporting ecosystem — telecom, cloud, vendors, remote access, and hiring pipelines — that NCSC describes.

Bottom line: The decisive variable is no longer detection of intrusion. It is whether an executive can answer, before a crisis, a single question: who has the authority and the means to sever a compromised access pathway in the first hour? This week's Iran, Russia, dark-fleet, and DPRK developments are not separate stories. They are four live illustrations of where that access already sits.

Section I

What Changed This Week

NCSC: Hostile States Pre-Positioning Inside Critical Infrastructure

On **17 June 2026**, NCSC CEO Dr. Richard Horne told the RUSI Annual Security Lecture that the agency handled **more than 200 cyber incidents** affecting UK critical infrastructure and its supporting ecosystem in the year to May 2026, with **about 75% linked to hostile state actors** — Russia, China, and Iran by name. Horne warned that adversaries “are pre-positioning today, establishing footholds within technology that underpins critical national infrastructure that could enable rapid exploitation to cause mass disruption in a time of conflict,” and that NCSC assesses it highly likely AI will let attackers exploit known legacy vulnerabilities at scale by 2028. The warning is UK-based, but the target logic — telecom, cloud, vendor, and identity pathways supporting essential services — maps directly onto Texas infrastructure dependencies.

Iran: Hormuz Closure Declared, Disputed, While Talks Continue

The U.S. and Iran signed an Islamabad memorandum of understanding on **17 June** extending their ceasefire 60 days and reopening the Strait of Hormuz. That arrangement began fracturing within 72 hours: on **20 June**, Iran's military command declared the Strait closed again, citing continued Israeli strikes in Lebanon and alleged U.S. failure to enforce the agreement's first clause. **U.S. Central Command and Vice President Vance dispute the claim**, stating the Strait remains open and that Iran does not control it. Technical-level talks between U.S. and Iranian delegations are proceeding in Switzerland as of 21 June. Separately, a **14 June** cyberattack disrupted the shared communications system serving four Iranian banks — Bank Mellī, Bank Saderat, Bank Tejarat, and the Export Development Bank of Iran — with temporary outages and no claimed data theft; reporting points to Israel-aligned activity, though attribution remains unconfirmed.

Russia: Ukrainian Strikes Take a Third of Refining Capacity Offline

Ukrainian drone strikes hit Gazprom Neft's Kapotnya refinery in Moscow twice in one week — **16 and 18 June**, the second wave involving roughly 200 drones — along with a Krasnodar oil depot. Kapotnya

supplies up to 40% of Moscow's gasoline. Industry assessments now put **roughly a third of Russia's primary refining capacity (over 2 million barrels per day) offline or impaired**, with fuel shortages spreading across more than 25 Russian regions. This is the most significant escalation yet in Ukraine's refinery campaign and directly raises Moscow's incentive for retaliatory or deniable cyber activity against Western infrastructure and energy-linked suppliers.

Dark-Fleet Tankers: USCG Cyber Command Finds Remote-Access and Wipe Tooling

The Wall Street Journal reported on USCG Cyber Command findings — on the record from **Rear Admiral Jason Tama** — that seized tankers carrying sanctioned Russian and Iranian oil commonly run constant internet links, remote-desktop software (AnyDesk, TeamViewer), GPS-spoofing equipment, multiple simultaneous AIS identities, and malware-laced pirated software wired into navigation and operational systems. In one case, crew attempted to remotely wipe data after U.S. boarding teams came aboard. The finding has already prompted the UK, France, and Germany to step up interdictions.

DPRK: Nisos Discloses Scale of AI-Enabled Employment Fraud

Nisos published research on **16 and 18 June** detailing a DPRK-linked employment-fraud cell — up to 22 operatives responsible for **166,893 job applications, 21,645 interviews, and 76 offers** across late 2024 and 2025 — using stolen identities, AI-assisted interview coaching, U.S.-based laptop farms with hardware remote-control (PiKVM), and cryptocurrency payouts. Members held positions at five U.S. companies during the monitoring window. The activity itself is not new this week; what changed is the published evidence of its industrial scale and tradecraft.

Section II

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses it is **very likely** (80–95%) that state-linked pre-positioning inside critical infrastructure and its supporting ecosystem extends beyond the UK to U.S. and Texas-relevant telecom, cloud, vendor, and identity pathways. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: NCSC CEO Richard Horne, RUSI Annual Security Lecture, 17 June 2026, confirmed against the primary NCSC publication. Primary uncertainty: the precise scope and depth of mirrored access inside U.S. private-sector infrastructure is not independently confirmed in open reporting this week; this is an analytic extension from adversary intent, target value, and ecosystem overlap.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Boards should test whether continuity plans assume cloud, telecom, and vendor access remain available — or whether they account for deliberate, pre-established compromise of those same dependencies.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that Iran will rely on deniable, proxy, or hacktivist cyber activity against U.S. public-service and energy-linked targets rather than overt state action, even if the Strait of Hormuz dispute escalates further. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Iran's 20 June Hormuz closure declaration disputed by CENTCOM and VP Vance; confirmed 14 June cyberattack on Iranian banking communications infrastructure; continuing Switzerland talks. Primary uncertainty: whether the MOU holds, whether talks produce a durable settlement, and whether Iran

shifts from declared to physical interdiction in the Strait.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, water, municipal, maritime, and finance leaders should pre-approve emergency isolation authority and public-disclosure thresholds now, rather than waiting for attribution during an active event.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that Russian cyber retaliation incentives against Western infrastructure and energy-linked suppliers have increased as Ukrainian strikes degrade a growing share of Russian refining capacity. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Confirmed Ukrainian strikes on the Kapotnya refinery (16, 18 June) and industry assessments of roughly one-third of Russian refining capacity offline. Primary uncertainty: whether Moscow responds primarily through conventional strikes, cyber retaliation, sabotage, influence operations, or continued technology acquisition — the form of response is not yet observable.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, refining, LNG, and logistics operators should review Russian-linked vendor exposure and confirm who can isolate a supplier or disconnect exposed support systems on short notice.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that DPRK employment-fraud access represents an executive-level insider-risk exposure for Texas AI, cloud, software, and defense-industrial employers that bypasses traditional security monitoring. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Nisos research releases, 16 and 18 June 2026, describing a confirmed 22-operative cell with verified application, interview, and offer volumes. Primary uncertainty: whether this disclosed cell represents the bulk of DPRK's employment-fraud operations or only one exposed fraction of a larger ecosystem.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: HR, security, engineering, and legal must jointly own remote-hire vetting. This cannot sit with SOC monitoring alone — the access is granted through hiring, not intrusion.

Section III

Geopolitical Driver

Four adversaries, four distinct geopolitical pressures, one shared executive problem. Russia faces deepening fuel-logistics and sanctions pressure as Ukrainian strikes erode refining capacity, raising its incentive to retaliate, collect, and signal against Western infrastructure and Ukraine's supporters. Iran is operating inside a 72-hour-old ceasefire that is already fracturing over Lebanon, raising the value of proxy and deniable cyber retaliation against U.S.-linked public-service and energy targets. China's pre-positioning interest in telecom, cloud, and identity pathways — the activity NCSC describes — remains tied to contingency planning for a future Indo-Pacific crisis. North Korea continues scaling employment fraud and developer access to generate sanctions-evading revenue for its weapons programs. Texas matters because its energy, port, finance, healthcare, defense, and AI/data-center concentration gives all four adversaries multiple paths to create leverage beyond their immediate target.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Continuum assessment: Liberty CTI assesses Texas critical infrastructure remains in **competition**, transitioning toward **crisis** for energy, maritime, and finance-adjacent sectors given the live Hormuz dispute. The indicators that matter are not new intrusions — they are signals that pre-positioned access is being activated: vendor isolation failures, telecom or cloud degradation, and retaliatory claims timed to geopolitical triggers.

Section IV

Why This Matters to Texas

Texas is not a collection of separately targeted sectors. It is a coupled system in which energy enables logistics and finance, finance enables recovery, healthcare carries immediate human consequence, and the defense-industrial base carries national security consequence. This week’s reporting shows the access adversaries would use to create that cascade already exists — inside telecom and cloud ecosystems (NCSC), inside maritime and energy logistics (dark-fleet), inside banking communications infrastructure (Iran), and inside hiring pipelines for technology and defense employers (DPRK). The board-level risk is not a single cyber event. It is discovering, mid-crisis, that no one owns the decision to sever the dependency that just became a liability.

Cross-Sector Cascade Assessment

Energy Maritime / Refining / OT	What changed: Iran declared the Strait of Hormuz closed on 20 June (disputed by CENTCOM); USCG Cyber Command confirmed remote-access and GPS-spoofing tooling aboard dark-fleet tankers carrying Russian and Iranian oil. Why it matters locally: Texas refining, LNG, port, and energy-trading operations sit inside the same maritime ecosystem and price-shock exposure. Decision-relevant action: Confirm who can isolate a vendor or sever remote access into fuel-logistics and terminal OT on short notice; add cyber and AIS-anomaly criteria to vessel vetting and port-access screening. Cascade risk: Energy and maritime disruption extends to finance, logistics, and public-service continuity within hours.
Financial Shared Infrastructure / Retaliation Risk	What changed: A 14 June cyberattack on shared communications infrastructure disrupted four major Iranian banks simultaneously. Why it matters locally: The incident is a single-point-of-failure lesson — one shared layer took four institutions down at once — and confirms the Iran cyber front is live and bidirectional, raising Iran’s incentive to reach for deniable retaliatory effects against U.S.-linked finance targets. Decision-relevant action: Texas banks, credit unions, and payment processors should test third-party and shared-service communications dependencies and public-portal DDoS resilience this week. Cascade risk: Finance-sector degradation during an energy or telecom disruption extends restoration timelines from hours to days.

**Healthcare / DIB /
AI Hiring as an
Access Vector**

What changed: Nisos disclosed the scale of a DPRK employment-fraud cell — 166,893 applications, 21,645 interviews, 76 offers — using AI-assisted interviews and U.S.-based laptop farms with hardware remote control. **Why it matters locally:** For Texas AI, cloud, software, defense-supplier, and hospital-system employers, this access route bypasses the SOC entirely — high-trust access granted through hiring into source repositories, cloud permissions, and customer environments. **Decision-relevant action:** Audit remote hires and contractors from the past six months; revalidate identity, laptop custody, location consistency, and access scope jointly across HR, security, and legal. **Cascade risk:** A single compromised hire can reach customer environments, code-signing systems, and downstream supply-chain partners.

Section V

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 3 / I&W 1 Hormuz: declaration versus physical interdiction [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for Iran moving from declaring the Strait closed to physically interdicting vessel traffic, and whether the 21 June Switzerland talks hold or collapse.
- Physical interdiction would confirm escalation from coercive signaling to action and is the trigger most likely to convert latent Iranian cyber access into use against U.S.-linked energy and public-service targets.
- Tied to: PIR 3, geopolitical escalation indicators.

PIR 5 / I&W 2 Pro-Iran retaliatory cyber claims timed to Hormuz or Lebanon developments [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for IRGC-linked or hacktivist DDoS, defacement, or PLC/HMI scanning against U.S. water utilities, energy public portals, and finance targets, paired with data-leak threats timed to the political moment.
- Would confirm Iran is shifting from declared posture to executed retaliation against soft U.S.-linked targets.
- Tied to: PIR 5, strategic vulnerability exposure across critical infrastructure.

PIR 1 / I&W 3 Russian-aligned targeting of energy logistics and refinery vendors [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for hacktivist claims or intrusions against refinery vendors, fuel-transport OT, and maritime systems, plus influence messaging tied to Western support for Ukraine.
- Would confirm Russia is converting refinery-strike pressure into cyber retaliation rather than relying solely on conventional response.
- Tied to: PIR 1, nation-state targeting of Texas-relevant critical infrastructure.

PIR 6 / I&W 4 New dark-fleet interdictions or AIS-anomaly advisories [*→ Sustained*]

- Watch for additional USCG or allied (UK, France, Germany) tanker interdictions, and AIS-spoofing or remote-access anomalies on vessels approaching Gulf and Texas ports.
- Would confirm the dark-fleet cyber-safety exposure is widespread rather than isolated to vessels already inspected.
- Tied to: PIR 6, executive decision-relevant warning for Texas maritime and energy operators.

PIR 4 / I&W 5 Follow-on DPRK employment-fraud disclosures or enforcement [*→ Sustained*]

- Watch for additional Nisos or vendor disclosures, DOJ indictments, OFAC designations, or internal HR/security flags on remote hires (laptop-farm shipping addresses, VPN logins, off-hours patterns, AI-assisted interview tells).

- Would confirm whether the disclosed 22-operative cell is representative of a larger, still-active ecosystem.
- Tied to: PIR 4, sector specificity for AI, cloud, DIB, and software employers.

Section VI

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether leadership treats pre-positioned access as a strategic warning requiring control of access pathways now, versus routine intrusion activity to be patched later.
Owner	CEO/COO, CISO, CIO, and general counsel for dependency and vendor-isolation authority; HR and engineering leadership for hiring-based access; operations and port/maritime leadership for OT and vessel-facing systems.
Consequence of delay	When a trigger fires — Hormuz interdiction, refinery-strike escalation, or Iranian retaliation — the organization discovers it cannot quickly isolate a vendor, cut remote access, communicate without compromised telecom or cloud, or prove what happened. Latent access becomes operational downtime, safety exposure, and regulatory liability.
Action this week	Run a 72-hour dependency drill identifying the top five external dependencies that would halt operations if degraded. Confirm in writing who holds emergency authority to isolate a vendor, sever remote access, and approve public disclosure. Revalidate remote hires and contractors onboarded in the past six months.
Record to preserve	Dependency maps, vendor and remote-access logs, incident decision-authority matrix, continuity plans, AIS and vessel-vetting records, interview recordings and identity checks for remote hires, and any adversary or hacktivist claims tied to the above.

Section VII

Actions This Week

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Ask: Who has the authority and the means to sever a compromised vendor, remote-access pathway, or telecom/cloud dependency in the first hour of a crisis?

Approve: A 72-hour dependency drill identifying the top five external dependencies that would stop operations if degraded.

Document: Emergency isolation authority, public-disclosure thresholds, and identity/access revalidation for remote hires from the past six months.

Rehearse: One scenario combining vendor or remote-access compromise with a geopolitical trigger — Hormuz interdiction, refinery-strike retaliation, or shared-infrastructure outage.

Section VIII

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-14 assessed Iran as the centerpiece adversary following the confirmed Handala/Void Manticore retaliatory cyber operation against California Water Service, tied to active U.S.-Iran conflict.
Current status	Escalated and reframed. Iran remains a live concern — the 20 June Hormuz closure declaration and 14 June bank disruption confirm the conflict's cyber dimension is active — but this week's dominant judgment widens the frame: NCSC confirms pre-positioning is a multi-adversary pattern (Russia, China, Iran), not an Iran-specific dynamic.
What changed	The centerpiece moved from a single confirmed Iranian retaliatory incident to a confirmed structural finding: state actors across all three named adversaries are deliberately pre-positioning for crisis leverage, with Iran, Russia, dark-fleet, and DPRK activity this week each illustrating where that access sits.
Confidence movement	Confidence in the pre-positioning judgment increased to High because the NCSC finding is primary-sourced and explicit, and four independent developments this week are each consistent with access existing ahead of activation rather than being created in response to events.
Next indicator	Physical Hormuz interdiction, a named Texas or U.S. victim tied to any of this week's four threads, or a confirmed U.S. CNI incident attributed to pre-positioned access would raise escalation posture from competition to crisis.

Section IX — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-15 — COVERAGE WEEK 14–20 JUNE 2026

GOVERNMENT / OFFICIAL REMARKS

NCSC — CEO Hostile States Linked to Three-Quarters of Cyber Attacks

ncsc.gov.uk/news/ncsc-ceo-hostile-states-linked-to-three-quarters-of-cyber-attacks

Published 17 June 2026. Primary source — verified against agency publication directly. Used for Dominant Judgment, KJ-1, and Geopolitical Driver.

GOVERNMENT / MILITARY STATEMENT

U.S. Central Command Statement Disputing Iranian Strait of Hormuz Closure Claim

cnn.com/2026/06/20/world/live-news/iran-war-trump-israel-lebanon

20 June 2026. CENTCOM and VP Vance statements reported via live wire coverage. Used for What Changed and KJ-2.

GOVERNMENT / OFFICIAL ATTRIBUTION

USCG Cyber Command Findings on Dark-Fleet Tanker Cyber Exposure

wsj.com — The Dangerous Tech Found Aboard 'Dark-Fleet' Tankers Captured by the U.S.

15 June 2026. On-the-record finding from Rear Admiral Jason Tama, USCG Cyber Command. Used for What Changed, Energy implication, and I&W 4.

VENDOR RESEARCH (NAMED INVESTIGATION)

Nisos — People, Process, Personas: DPRK Employment Fraud Research

nisos.com/research/dprk-employment-fraud-operation/

16–18 June 2026. Verified against Nisos' own publication, not secondary summary. Used for KJ-4, Healthcare/DIB/AI implication, and I&W 5.

STATE MEDIA / FINANCIAL REGULATOR STATEMENT

Iran Banking Coordination Council — Statement on Four-Bank Cyber Disruption

thenews.com.pk – Four Iranian banks hit by cyberattack, prompting major service disruptions

14 June 2026. Iranian official statement reported via wire/press. Attribution of the attack itself is unconfirmed in open reporting. Used for Finance implication.

WIRE / MULTI-SOURCE

Reuters/AP/Al Jazeera — U.S.-Iran Islamabad MOU Signing and Ceasefire Extension

aljazeera.com/news/2026/6/17/iran-confirms-that-mou-has-been-signed-electronically-by-both-sides

14–17 June 2026. Cited for ceasefire and MOU sequencing context only.

INDUSTRY / OSINT

Kyiv Post / Energy News Beat — Kapotnya Refinery Strike Reporting and Capacity Impact Estimates

kyivpost.com/post/78244

16–18 June 2026. Capacity-loss figures are industry/OSINT estimates, not official Russian or Ukrainian government data. Cited for refinery-impact scale only.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: NCSC confirmed on 17 June that state actors are deliberately pre-positioning inside critical infrastructure for crisis-time exploitation, with 75% of 200+ UK CNI incidents over the past year linked to Russia, China, or Iran. The same week, the U.S.-Iran ceasefire began fracturing with a disputed Hormuz closure declaration, Ukrainian strikes took roughly a third of Russian refining capacity offline, USCG Cyber Command confirmed remote-access and wipe tooling aboard dark-fleet tankers, and Nisos disclosed the scale of a DPRK employment-fraud cell. **WHO:** NCSC, CENTCOM, USCG Cyber Command, and Nisos define this week's primary evidence base. Russia, China, Iran, and North Korea remain the four standing adversary actors tracked each issue. **WHY:** Russia's fuel-logistics pressure raises retaliation incentive; Iran's fracturing ceasefire raises proxy and deniable retaliation incentive; China's pre-positioning interest remains tied to future Indo-Pacific contingency; North Korea continues scaling sanctions-evading revenue and access through employment fraud. Texas matters because energy, port, finance, healthcare, defense, and AI/data-center concentration gives all four adversaries multiple paths to leverage. **WHAT NEXT:** Leadership should expect this pattern to be the baseline, not a one-week event. The task is not detecting the next intrusion — it is knowing, before a Hormuz interdiction or refinery-strike escalation, who controls the access pathway and who can shut it off. *Warnings that arrive too late are not warnings. They are after-action reports.*

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